Visual Vocabulary

288 terms · name, then the phrase to paste · Workbook Library

Visual style

Flat flat vector illustration, solid fills, no gradients or shadows

3D isometric 3D isometric illustration, 30° angles, no perspective distortion, soft shading on each face

Line art monoline line art, consistent 2px stroke, no fills

Skeuomorphic skeuomorphic style, realistic materials, bevels and highlights like a physical object

Neumorphism neumorphic soft UI, elements extruded from the background with soft light and dark shadows

Glassmorphism glassmorphism, frosted translucent panels with background blur over soft color blobs

Claymorphism soft 3D clay style, rounded puffy shapes, matte material, gentle studio lighting

Low-poly low-poly style, faceted triangles with flat shading

Hand-drawn hand-drawn sketchy style like Excalidraw, wobbly marker lines, casual

Pixel art 8-bit pixel art, visible square pixels, limited palette

Blueprint blueprint style, white technical linework on a blue grid, dimension annotations

Wireframe low-fidelity wireframe, grey boxes and placeholder lines, no styling

Front view straight-on front view, orthographic, no perspective

Perspective one-point perspective with a central vanishing point, depth receding into the distance

Top-down top-down bird's-eye view, map-like layout

Exploded view exploded view, layers separated vertically with dashed guide lines showing how they stack

Cutaway cutaway illustration with a wedge removed to reveal the inner layers

Elevation cards at different elevations, soft drop shadows indicating depth

Depth of field shallow depth of field, sharp subject, softly blurred background

Monochromatic monochromatic palette, shades and tints of a single blue

Analogous analogous palette of neighboring hues (teal, green, lime)

Complementary complementary palette, blue paired with orange accents

Pastel soft pastel palette, light and low saturation

Muted muted desaturated palette, dusty tones, nothing fully saturated

High contrast high-contrast palette, black and white with one bold yellow

Neon on dark dark background with glowing neon accents in magenta and cyan

One accent color mostly neutral palette with a single accent color used only for emphasis

Gradient smooth gradient background blending purple into coral

Duotone duotone treatment, every image in deep navy and hot pink only

Warm vs. cool warm colors for the problem side, cool colors for the solution side

Semantic color semantic status colors: green for success, amber for warning, red for error

Hue keep all colors within a narrow hue range around [color]

Saturation low-saturation palette with one fully saturated accent

Value strong value structure: clear separation of lights and darks that reads even in grayscale

Tints, tones & shades palette built from tints and shades of a single [color]

Triadic triadic color scheme of [color], [color] and [color], with one dominant

Split-complementary split-complementary palette: [main color] with the two neighbors of its complement as accents

Serif elegant serif typeface for headings

Sans-serif clean geometric sans-serif typeface

Monospace monospace typeface for labels and data, developer aesthetic

Display type bold expressive display typeface for the headline only

Handwritten handwritten marker-style font for annotations

Type scale clear type scale with distinct H1, H2 and body sizes

Weight contrast strong weight contrast, ultra-bold keywords next to light text

Letter-spacing wide letter-spacing on small uppercase labels, tight tracking on large headlines

Eyebrow label small uppercase eyebrow label above each heading

Kerning carefully kerned headline with optically even letter spacing

Leading tight leading on headlines, generous 1.5 line height for body text

Type pairing type pairing: [serif] for headings with [sans-serif] for body text

Drop cap editorial layout with a large serif drop cap starting the first paragraph

Line length body text limited to about 65 characters per line

Corner radius softly rounded corners on all shapes, pill-shaped buttons

Geometric geometric shapes only: circles, squares and triangles with crisp edges

Organic organic blob shapes and flowing curves, nothing perfectly geometric

Stroke weight consistent medium stroke weight on all lines and icons

Grain subtle grain texture over flat colors, risograph print feel

Background pattern faint dot-grid background like a design canvas

Solid vs. dashed solid arrows for the main path, dashed arrows for optional or async steps

Glow soft glow around the key element, like light emission

Minimalist minimalist: few elements, restrained color, lots of white space

Swiss style Swiss International style: strict grid, bold flush-left sans-serif, asymmetric layout, red accent

Bauhaus Bauhaus style: primary colors, black, bold geometric shapes

Brutalist neo-brutalist style: thick black outlines, hard offset shadows, flat bright colors

Editorial editorial magazine style: large serif headline, text columns, generous margins

Memphis Memphis design style: squiggles, zigzags, confetti shapes, pastel colors with black accents

Synthwave synthwave retro-futurist style: neon sunset, glowing perspective grid, purple and magenta

Terminal terminal aesthetic: green monospace text on black, blinking cursor

Vintage travel poster vintage travel-poster style: limited palette of flat screen-print inks, halftone and grain shading, bold simple silhouettes, warm paper texture

3D

Axonometric dimetric axonometric view, parallel projection, no vanishing point

Three-quarter view three-quarter view from slightly above, showing front, side and top

Low angle dramatic low-angle shot looking up at the subject

Studio lighting soft studio lighting from a large softbox, gentle gradients and soft shadows

Rim light strong rim lighting from behind, glowing edges against a dark background

Contact shadows soft contact shadows and ambient occlusion so objects feel grounded

Matte vs. glossy matte surfaces with no reflections (or: glossy with sharp specular highlights)

Glass & translucency translucent glass material with refraction, background visible and slightly distorted through it

Chrome & metal polished chrome material reflecting a bright sky and dark horizon

3D wireframe 3D wireframe mesh rendering, glowing grid lines, no solid surfaces

Voxel art voxel art, scene built from small uniform cubes

Diorama isometric diorama: a miniature room with two walls cut away, objects arranged inside

Floating objects objects floating in mid-air with soft shadows on the ground beneath

Cel-shaded cel-shaded toon rendering, hard-edged shadow bands and bold outlines

Extruded type chunky extruded 3D lettering with visible depth

Orbit / turntable slow 360° turntable rotation around the object

Soft 3D render clean soft 3D render in the style of Cinema 4D or Blender, global illumination, seamless pastel backdrop

UI & UX

Density compact, information-dense layout with tight row height (or: comfortable density with generous row spacing)

Affordance clear affordances: buttons look pressable, draggable items show grab handles, inputs look editable

Progressive disclosure progressive disclosure: show the essential options first, tuck advanced settings behind an expandable section

Empty state friendly empty state: small illustration, one line explaining what goes here, and a single primary button to start

Skeleton screen skeleton loading state: grey placeholder blocks shaped like the content, with a gentle shimmer

Modal dialog centered modal dialog over a dimmed backdrop, with a title, short message and two buttons

Drawer slide-over drawer from the right edge showing details, page dimmed behind it

Toast brief toast notification at the bottom of the screen confirming the action, auto-dismisses

Tabs tab bar across the top of the panel with an underline on the active tab

Breadcrumbs breadcrumb trail above the page title showing the path back up the hierarchy

Command palette command palette opened with ⌘K: search input on top, filtered list of commands with one highlighted

Button hierarchy clear button hierarchy: one filled primary action, an outlined secondary, a text-link tertiary

Interaction states design every interaction state: default, hover, focus ring, pressed and disabled

Inline validation inline form validation: error message directly under the field in red, success check when valid

Tooltip small dark tooltip with an arrow appearing above the icon on hover

Responsive layout responsive layout: three columns on desktop, two on tablet, a single stacked column on mobile

Grid layout strict 12-column grid, elements aligned to column edges

Bento grid bento grid layout, rounded tiles of varied sizes packed into a tidy rectangle

Card layout card layout, equal cards in a row each with image, title and short text

Hero section bold hero section: large headline, one-line subhead and a single call-to-action button

Split screen split-screen layout, image on the left half and text on the right half

Masonry masonry layout, columns of uneven-height tiles packed tightly

Negative space generous negative space, few elements, lots of breathing room

Visual hierarchy strong visual hierarchy: one dominant headline, a clear secondary level, quiet body text

Rule of thirds rule-of-thirds composition, subject placed off-center on a third line

Asymmetric balance asymmetric but balanced composition, large element offset by smaller ones

Sidebar + content app layout with a left sidebar for navigation and a main content area of panels

Leading lines use leading lines: a road or reflection runs from the bottom of the frame straight to the subject

Easing smooth ease-in-out transitions, nothing linear

Spring springy motion with a slight overshoot and settle

Stagger staggered entrance, items appear one after another with a short delay

Fade and slide elements fade in while sliding up a few pixels

Morph shape morphs smoothly from one form into the next

Pulse subtle pulsing ring to show the element is live

Flowing dashes animated dashed connectors showing data flowing along each arrow

Parallax parallax effect, foreground layers move faster than background layers

Build-up diagram builds up step by step, one component at a time in explanation order

Micro-interaction small micro-interactions on buttons: press feedback and a success state

Principles & critique

Proximity use proximity to group related items: tight spacing within groups, larger gaps between groups

Similarity use similarity: items with the same role share the same color and shape

Common region use common region: wrap related controls in a subtle tinted container

Continuity use continuity: arrange steps along one smooth path so the eye follows them in order

Closure use closure: suggest the shape with partial outlines and let negative space complete it

Figure and ground play with figure and ground: let the negative space form a second shape

Contrast use contrast to make one element clearly dominant; keep everything else quiet

Alignment strict alignment: elements share left edges and baselines on a consistent grid

Repetition consistent visual system: repeat the same card style, spacing and accent across every section

Rhythm create a steady visual rhythm with evenly repeated elements and consistent intervals

Symmetry symmetrical composition mirrored around a central vertical axis

Visual weight balance visual weight: offset the heavy dark element with several lighter ones on the other side

Scale contrast extreme scale contrast: a tiny subject dwarfed by an enormous shape that fills the frame

Visual metaphor built around one clear visual metaphor for [idea], shown without any text

Visual noise reduce visual noise: remove non-essential elements, establish one clear hierarchy, add whitespace

Tight spacing increase spacing: generous padding inside containers and consistent gaps between elements

Weak grouping fix grouping: keep each label close to its value and add larger gaps between groups

Misalignment fix alignment: snap all elements to a shared left edge and consistent grid

Color overload calm the palette: mostly neutrals with a single accent color reserved for emphasis

No focal point create a focal point: make the key element significantly larger or more colorful than the rest

Poor legibility improve legibility: higher text contrast, larger body size, line length around 65 characters, more line spacing

Inconsistency make it consistent: one corner radius, one icon style, a fixed type scale and spacing system

Heavy visual weight lighten the visual weight: thin subtle borders, light tinted fills, fewer heavy shadows

Dated styling modernize the styling: flat surfaces, subtle shadows, no gloss or bevels, contemporary sans-serif type

No point of view give it a point of view: one distinctive typeface and color, an asymmetric layout, avoid template defaults

Over-decoration strip back decoration: remove gradients, extra borders and effects that don't carry meaning

Lopsided balance rebalance the composition: distribute visual weight across the frame

Diagrams & charts

Flowchart flowchart with step boxes, decision diamonds and labelled yes/no branches

Sequence diagram sequence diagram with lifelines for each actor and numbered messages flowing downward

Pipeline left-to-right pipeline diagram, each stage a box transforming the data, arrows between stages

Layer stack layer stack diagram, horizontal bands from foundation at the bottom to user-facing at the top

Hub and spoke hub-and-spoke diagram with a central node and satellites around it

Tree top-down tree diagram showing parent-child hierarchy

Network graph network graph of nodes and connecting edges, key nodes larger and highlighted

Swimlane swimlane diagram with one lane per actor, steps hopping between lanes

Timeline horizontal timeline with dated milestones, labels alternating above and below

Venn diagram Venn diagram of overlapping translucent circles, shared area labelled

2×2 matrix 2x2 quadrant matrix with labelled axes and items plotted in each quadrant

Funnel funnel diagram with stages narrowing from top to bottom

Annotated callouts annotated callouts, short labels connected to parts by thin leader lines with dots

Zoom inset zoom inset: a small highlighted region magnified in a circle beside the main image

Before / after side-by-side before/after comparison, same framing in both panels

Small multiples small multiples: a grid of identical mini charts sharing the same axes

Cycle cycle diagram with steps around a circle and curved arrows looping back

Sankey Sankey diagram, band widths proportional to the amount flowing between stages

Heatmap heatmap grid, single hue from pale to saturated showing intensity

Bar chart clean bar chart, one highlighted bar, others in muted gray, direct value labels

Line chart line chart of [metric] over time, soft area fill under the line, end point labeled

Scatter plot scatter plot with a faint trend line and outliers highlighted

Sparkline & KPI KPI stat cards: big number, small label, green or red delta and an inline sparkline

Donut chart donut chart with three segments and the total in the center

Stacked area stacked area chart of [parts] over time, soft distinct colors, total on top

Treemap treemap of [items] sized by value, grouped by category with subtle borders

Illustration & icons

Outline icons outline icons with a consistent 1.5px stroke and rounded joins

Filled icons solid filled glyph icons, simple silhouettes

Duotone icons duotone icons: light tint fill with darker accent details in the same hue

Line and offset fill line icons with an offset flat color fill shifted slightly behind the outline

3D icons soft 3D rendered icons with glossy highlights and gentle shadows

Sticker style sticker-style illustrations with a thick white die-cut border and a soft drop shadow, slightly rotated

Pictogram pictogram style: ultra-simplified geometric figures, white on a solid colored square, like airport signage

Spot illustration small spot illustrations beside the text, no background frame, simple shapes in the brand palette

Corporate Memphis Corporate Memphis style: flat people with small heads, exaggerated long limbs, non-realistic skin colors, blob shapes

Mascot friendly brand mascot character: simple rounded shape, big expressive eyes, used in empty and error states

Watercolor loose watercolor illustration, soft bleeding edges, transparent layered washes on textured paper

Crosshatching pen-and-ink crosshatching, shading built from layered parallel lines

Linocut linocut print style, bold black and white, visible carving marks and rough edges

Halftone halftone dot shading, regular dot grid varying in size to create tone

Screen print risograph screen-print style, two or three flat inks, overlapping colors, slight misregistration and grain

Collage paper collage style, torn edges, mixed textures and cut-out shapes layered at angles

Layered paper layered paper-cut illustration, stacked cut-out layers with soft shadows between them

Stippling stippling dotwork illustration, shading built from dense tiny dots

Spot color separation flat color separation in [N] spot inks: [ink] for [use], [ink] for [use]; no blended gradients

Lost and found edges lost and found edges: the subject's outline is crisp at the bottom and dissolves into the light at the top

Misregistration slight misregistration between ink layers, thin slivers of paper showing at the edges

Overprint overprinted transparent inks that mix into new colors where shapes overlap

Brand & logos

Wordmark wordmark logo: the name "[name]" in a custom [geometric / serif / rounded] typeface, no symbol

Lettermark lettermark logo using the initials "[ABC]", bold and compact

Monogram interlocking monogram of the letters [A] and [B], elegant and symmetrical

Pictorial mark pictorial logo mark: a simplified [object] symbol, works at 16px

Abstract mark abstract geometric logo mark suggesting [idea], simple enough to draw from memory

Emblem emblem logo: badge shape with "[name]" around the edge and a [symbol] in the center

Combination mark combination mark: a simple [symbol] next to the wordmark "[name]", horizontal lockup

Brand identity system a brand identity system for [name]: logo, primary and secondary colors, type pairing, a graphic pattern and example applications

Textures & mediums

Canvas visible canvas weave texture showing through the paint

Paper grain textured cold-press paper surface, visible paper tooth under the color

Kraft paper printed on brown kraft paper with visible fibers and flecks

Grain shading flat shapes shaded with fine grainy stipple texture instead of smooth gradients

Halftone gradient halftone dot gradients for shading, dots shrinking toward the light, flat screen-print inks

Distressed print distressed vintage print texture, worn and speckled ink, slightly faded

Linen & fabric soft linen fabric texture as the background

Concrete & plaster raw concrete texture, mottled grey with small pits

Wood grain warm natural wood grain texture

Crumpled paper crumpled paper texture with soft creases and folds

Brushed metal brushed aluminum texture with fine horizontal streaks and a soft sheen

Grainy gradient soft grainy gradient background with visible fine noise

Uncoated paper printed on uncoated matte paper: inks soaked in and slightly muted, soft edges, visible paper tooth

Oil paint oil painting with thick impasto brushstrokes catching the light

Gouache gouache painting: flat matte opaque color shapes with soft brushy edges

Pastel & chalk soft pastel drawing on dark paper, grainy powdery strokes

Charcoal expressive charcoal drawing, smudged soft shading and bold dark lines

Colored pencil colored pencil illustration, visible directional strokes and paper texture

Marker marker rendering: bold translucent strokes with darker overlaps, over a black ink line drawing

Airbrush 1980s airbrush illustration: ultra-smooth gradients, soft glowing edges, fine spray speckle

Ink wash sumi-e ink wash painting: grey washes, expressive black brushstrokes, generous empty space

Spray paint spray-painted graffiti style: bold outlined lettering, soft overspray, paint drips on a concrete wall

Digital painting painterly digital concept art: soft brushes, smooth blends, glowing atmospheric light

Art & architecture

Impressionism impressionist painting style, short visible brushstrokes, soft dappled light, no hard outlines

Pointillism pointillism, image built from small dots of pure color

Ukiyo-e ukiyo-e woodblock print style, flat color areas, bold outlines, stylized waves, indigo and cream

Art Nouveau Art Nouveau style, flowing whiplash curves, floral ornament, arched decorative frame, muted olive and gold

Cubism cubist style, subject fractured into overlapping geometric planes seen from multiple angles, muted earthy palette

De Stijl De Stijl / Mondrian composition: black grid lines, white fields, primary red, yellow and blue blocks

Constructivism Russian constructivist poster style: dynamic diagonals, red and black on cream, bold geometric type

Art Deco Art Deco style: symmetrical geometric fans and sunbursts, stepped forms, thin gold linework on deep navy

Surrealism surrealist scene: realistic rendering of a dreamlike impossible situation, empty landscape, long shadows

Abstract Expressionism abstract expressionist style, energetic drips, splatters and gestural brushstrokes, no literal subject

Pop Art pop art comic style: Ben-Day dots, thick black outlines, flat primary colors, speech bubble

Op Art op art optical illusion pattern, high-contrast black and white shapes that appear to move

Classical neoclassical architecture: symmetrical facade, rows of columns, triangular pediment, pale stone

Gothic Gothic architecture: pointed arches, tall spires, rose window, vertical soaring stone facade

Art Deco architecture Art Deco skyscraper: stepped setbacks, sunburst crown, strong vertical lines, gold geometric ornament

Modernist modernist International Style architecture: white flat-roofed box on thin columns, ribbon windows, no ornament

Brutalism brutalist architecture: massive raw concrete blocks, repeated deep-set windows, heavy cantilevered forms

Mid-century modern mid-century modern style: low horizontal lines, butterfly roof, walls of glass, warm wood and stone, mustard and teal accents

Postmodern postmodern architecture: playful oversized classical motifs, broken pediment, pastel pink and teal

Deconstructivism deconstructivist architecture: fragmented tilted volumes, colliding angles and curved metal surfaces

Parametric parametric architecture: flowing curved form, repeated ribs that gradually shift, smooth white surfaces

Traditional Japanese traditional Japanese architecture: exposed timber frame, shoji paper screens, deep eaves, natural materials, calm modular grid

Photo & film

Establishing shot wide establishing shot showing the whole setting, people small in the frame

Medium shot medium shot framing the subject from the waist up

Close-up tight close-up on the face, filling the frame

Extreme close-up extreme close-up macro shot of a single detail filling the frame

Over-the-shoulder over-the-shoulder shot: blurred shoulder in the foreground, the other person in focus facing camera

Dutch angle Dutch angle: camera tilted so the horizon slants, uneasy tension

Golden hour golden hour lighting: low warm sun, long soft shadows, glowing amber tones

Blue hour blue hour: deep blue twilight sky, warm city lights just switching on

High-key high-key lighting: bright, airy, mostly white tones, minimal shadows

Low-key low-key chiaroscuro lighting: mostly darkness, one hard side light revealing half the subject

Silhouette silhouette: subject as a solid black shape against a bright backlit sky

Teal and orange cinematic teal-and-orange color grade, teal shadows, warm orange skin tones

Analog film look analog 35mm film look: visible grain, faded warm colors, soft contrast, light leaks

Long exposure long exposure photograph: smooth light trails streaking through a night scene

Flat lay flat lay photo from directly above, objects neatly arranged on a clean surface

Backlit backlit, contre-jour lighting: the sun directly behind the subject, glowing rim and soft haze

Foreground, midground, background clear foreground, midground and background layers: [near thing] in front, [subject] in the middle, [scenery] behind

Atmospheric perspective atmospheric perspective: distant layers fade lighter and bluer with lower contrast

Frame within a frame frame-within-a-frame composition: the subject seen through a [doorway, window, arch]

Tight crop tight crop: the subject fills the frame and bleeds off the edges

Aspect ratio composed for a [16:9 / 4:5 / 9:16] aspect ratio

Rule of odds group the [objects] in threes following the rule of odds

Golden ratio golden-ratio composition, subject placed at the eye of the spiral

Telephoto compression shot on a long telephoto lens, compressed perspective, enormous sun stacked behind the subject

Wide-angle wide-angle lens, exaggerated perspective with lines rushing to the center

Fisheye fisheye lens with strong barrel distortion and a curved horizon

Lens flare subtle lens flare from the sun in the corner, soft circular ghosts and a horizontal anamorphic streak

Animation & games

Stop-motion stop-motion animation look: handmade miniature set, felt and wood textures, real shallow-focus lighting

Claymation claymation style: chunky plasticine characters with visible fingerprints and soft waxy highlights

Cel animation traditional cel animation look: crisp ink-outlined flat-color character over a soft painted background

Kinetic typography kinetic typography: bold words scale and slide in on the beat, one phrase at a time

Motion graphics motion graphics style: flat vector shapes with springy easing, shapes morph and pop between scenes

PBR physically based rendering with realistic materials: brushed metal, matte rubber, glossy plastic

Hand-painted textures stylized 3D with hand-painted textures, painted edge highlights and soft painted shadows

Stylized realism stylized realism: chunky exaggerated shapes, saturated colors, soft realistic lighting and materials

Ghibli-like painterly painterly anime landscape in a Ghibli-like spirit: towering cumulus clouds, lush greens, warm summer light, cozy details

Game HUD game HUD overlay: health bar top-left, minimap bottom-right, minimal and out of the center